



If reel gadgets were real

A list of 10 gadgets from the world of films that we wish translated into reality.

<http://dgit.in/SmL0tK>



Carpool apps

Six apps to help you organize a more effective carpool.

<http://dgit.in/NgfYD2>

dynamic range. There was some clipping when shooting during clear sky conditions, but with overcast skies, the dynamic range was wide enough to allow for a good exposure of the foreground and background.

Moving into the studio, the ISO results didn't surprise us one bit. Up to ISO 1600, both the cameras render excellent noise free images and at ISO 3200, signs of luminance and chrominance start to creep in. At ISO 6400 is when we first see a difference in ISO performance, with the Alpha taking a larger hit in performance. Regardless, the images are still useable. Nikon D7000's native ISO tops out at 6400, but the Alpha 77 goes up to ISO 25600, with images at ISO 12800 being just barely useable.

Detail retention is definitely better on the Alpha 77 as compared to the D7000 thanks to the larger pixel count, however, the difference won't really show unless you're printing at poster size. The video on the two cameras, again is quite identical in quality in low light and otherwise, with excellent noise suppression and good dynamic

range. However, we seem to lean in the favor of the Alpha because of the stereo mics and the tilt-swivel screen that makes shooting a whole lot easier. However, the lack of a secondary memory slot means either purchasing very high capacity cards or being judicious about video recording.

Verdict

The **Sony Alpha 77** wins our **Best Buy** award in the semi-professional DSLR segment, but by a very, very small margin. The two cameras share much of their imaging DNA and while Sony is a performance beast with its 12 fps burst mode and weather sealing. The **Nikon D7000**, however, is a camera that has delivered excellent results with every shot, so we award it our **Editor's Pick** award.

Pro DSLR

Cameras in this segment are infused with the best imaging and performance DNA cooked up by the geniuses hidden away in the R&D labs of the camera giants. We're not just talking about a higher pixel count, but also full frame sensors, yielding effec-

tively larger pixel pitches, for better per-pixel quality.

Features and Design

We're looking here at the Nikon D800E which boasts of the largest pixel count on a full frame camera so far, a whopping 36 megapixels. In the other corner of the ring is the Canon 5D MarkIII, which has a 22 megapixel sensor, which Canon claims is a completely novel design. While the Nikon gets an EXPEED 3 processing chip to handle the massive amounts of data coming from the 36 megapixel sensor, the 5D MarkIII is beefed up with Canon's latest DIGIC 5+ image processor. Both these chips allow the cameras to reach a peak shooting speed of 6 frames per second (6fps for the D800E with grip attached, else 4fps).

The 5D MarkIII also gains a silent shutter mode, which, is surprisingly quiet. Of course, when using the silent shutter mode, the maximum burst mode comes down to 3.5 fps.

Both the cameras have acquired an all new focusing and metering system. While the metering systems do just what they're supposed to do, it's the focusing systems here that are the real attraction. The D800E employs a 51-point AF system with 15 cross type focus points, the same as in the D4. It is capable of focusing in light levels as low as -2EV. While the focusing performance was a given with the D800E, the 5D MarkIII has a focus capability that has left many pleasantly surprised. The main gripe about the 5D MarkII was its severely crippled AF, which had a hard time with low light. Canon has fixed that by infusing the 5D MarkIII with the same AF assembly found in the 1DX. This means that now, we can wield

the power of 61 focus points, 41 of which are cross type. In our focus tests, we found that the D800E's peripheral focus points had a difficult time locking focus in low light, but that was not the case with the 5D.

Build and Ergonomics

Both camera bodies are crafted from magnesium alloy and feature extensive weather sealing to withstand natural elements. Since the rain Gods are being generous these days, we tested the weather sealing on these two cameras by shooting in light rain with no adverse effects. While the D800E looks like a tank ready for battle, the 5D MarkIII's body is a lot more subtle, a lot more elegant.

Ergonomically, we favor the 5D MarkIII over the D800E. Canon, over the years has pretty much perfected the idea of ergonomic intuitiveness, that is, the layout of the buttons and dials on the 5D is minimal, requires minimal finger movement and provides instant one-hand-access to all the primary shooting settings such as WB, burst mode, shooting mode, aperture and shutter speed settings and ISO. We could access all these features using just one finger to push a button and then spinning a dial with our thumb, all while the camera was still stuck to our eye. Sadly, the D800E does not offer the same level of comfort.

Performance

We're talking about a camera that's the successor to a very successful studio and video camera (the 5D MarkII) and a camera that's shocked the world with an incredulous pixel count. In our outdoor test, the D800 rendered vibrant images, while the 5D MarkIII files were a little flat, as can be expected when shooting RAW.



Canon 650D